



City of Cambridge

COF 2026-84
FIRST IN COUNCIL
June 2, 2026

A true copy;

ATTEST:-

A handwritten signature in cursive script, reading "Paula M. Crane".

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk



City of Cambridge

A communication was received from Melissa Peters, Assistant City Manager for Community Development, transmitting a presentation related to Cambridge Street zoning.

Neighborhood & Long-term Planning Committee Meeting: Cambridge Street

06/02/26



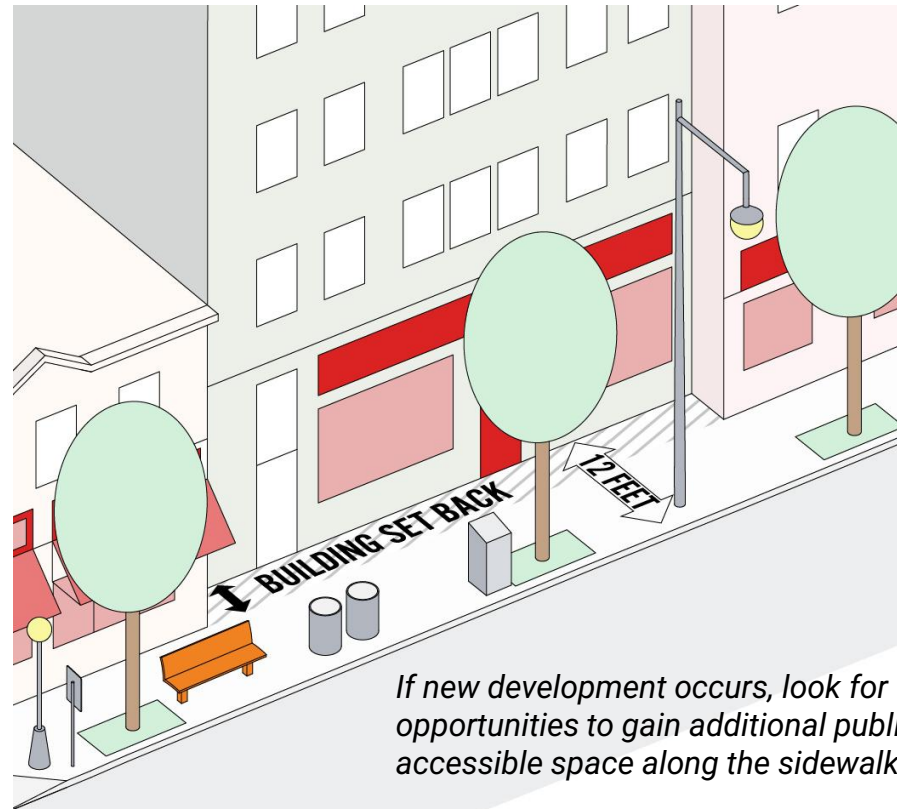
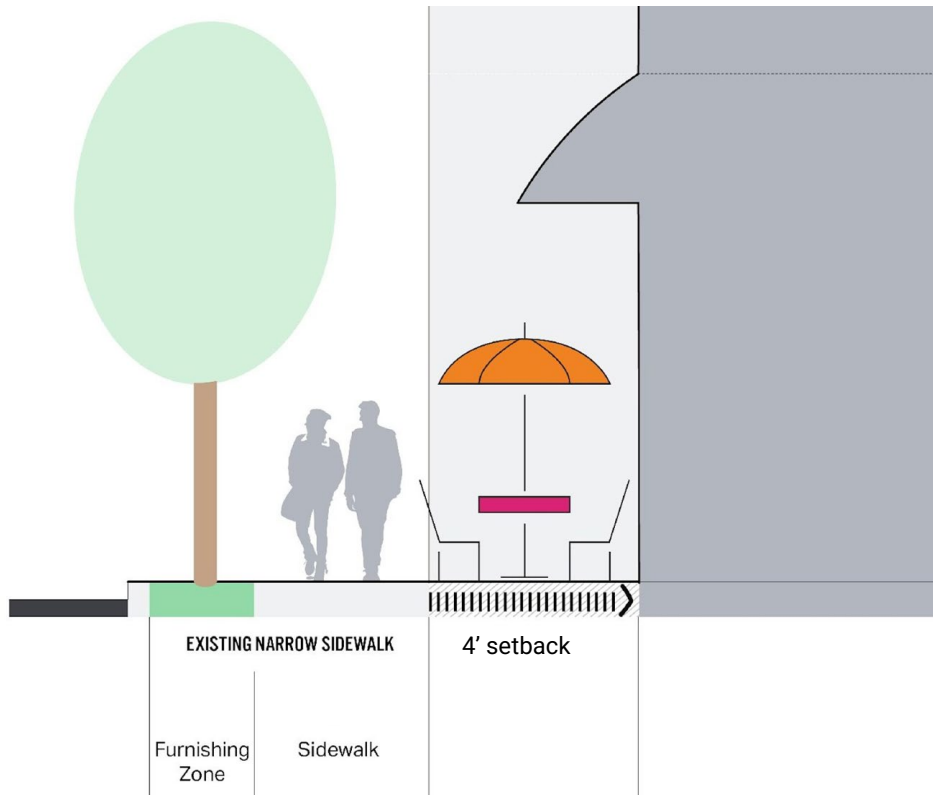
a community plan

DISCUSSION TOPICS FOR CAMBRIDGE STREET

1. Urban Form
2. Open Space
3. Design review
4. Non-residential Uses

URBAN FORM: Current zoning includes design standards to improve the public realm

- Small setbacks are required for new construction to allow for additional pedestrian space and amenities where appropriate. This reflects the recommendations of Citywide Urban Design Guidelines.
- Additional sidewalk could also be used to enhance plantings or to provide enhanced ADA accessibility.
- A development over 25K sf must plant street trees subject to DPW approval and in accordance with the Urban Forest Master Plan.

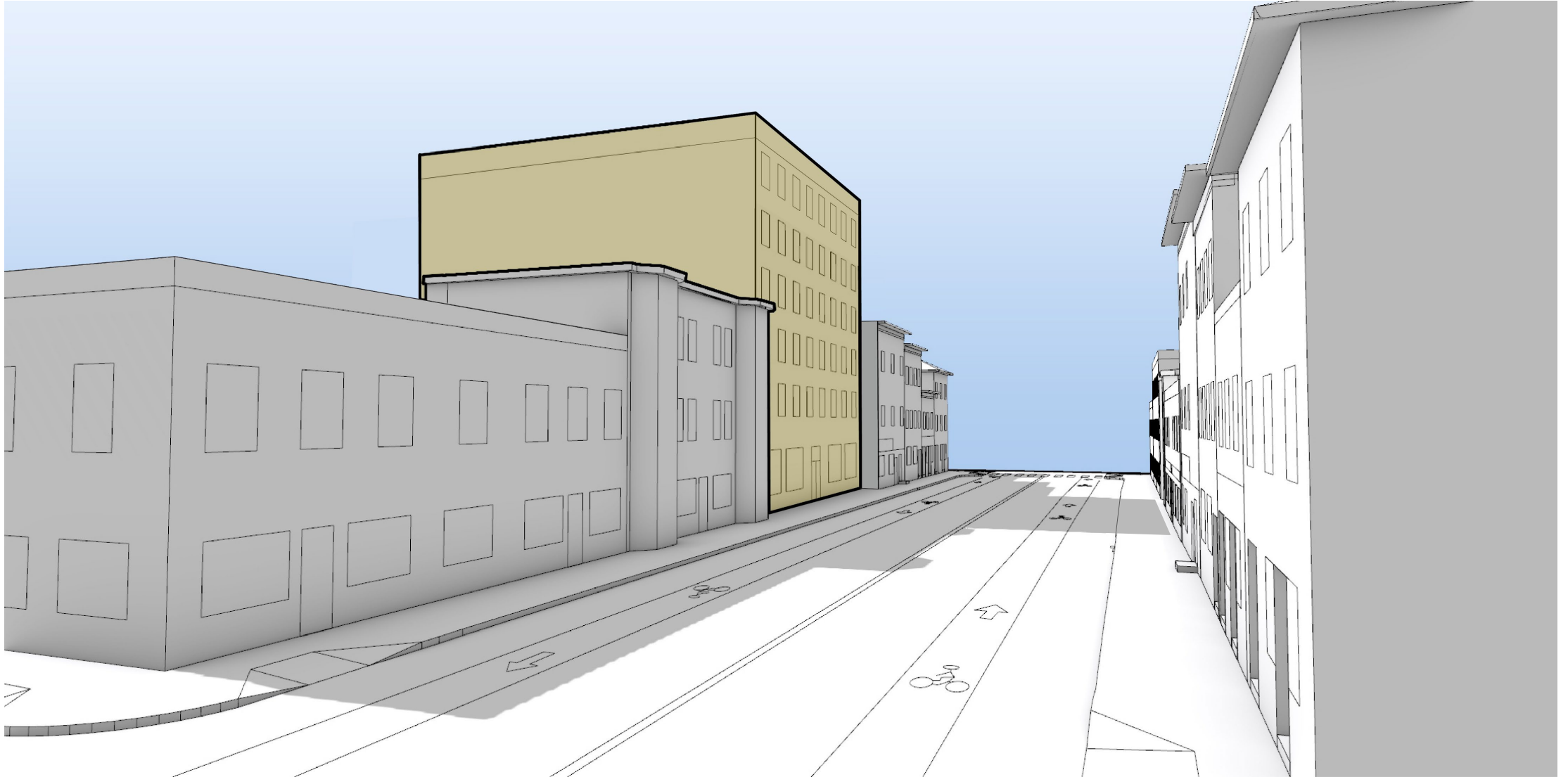


If new development occurs, look for opportunities to gain additional publicly accessible space along the sidewalk.

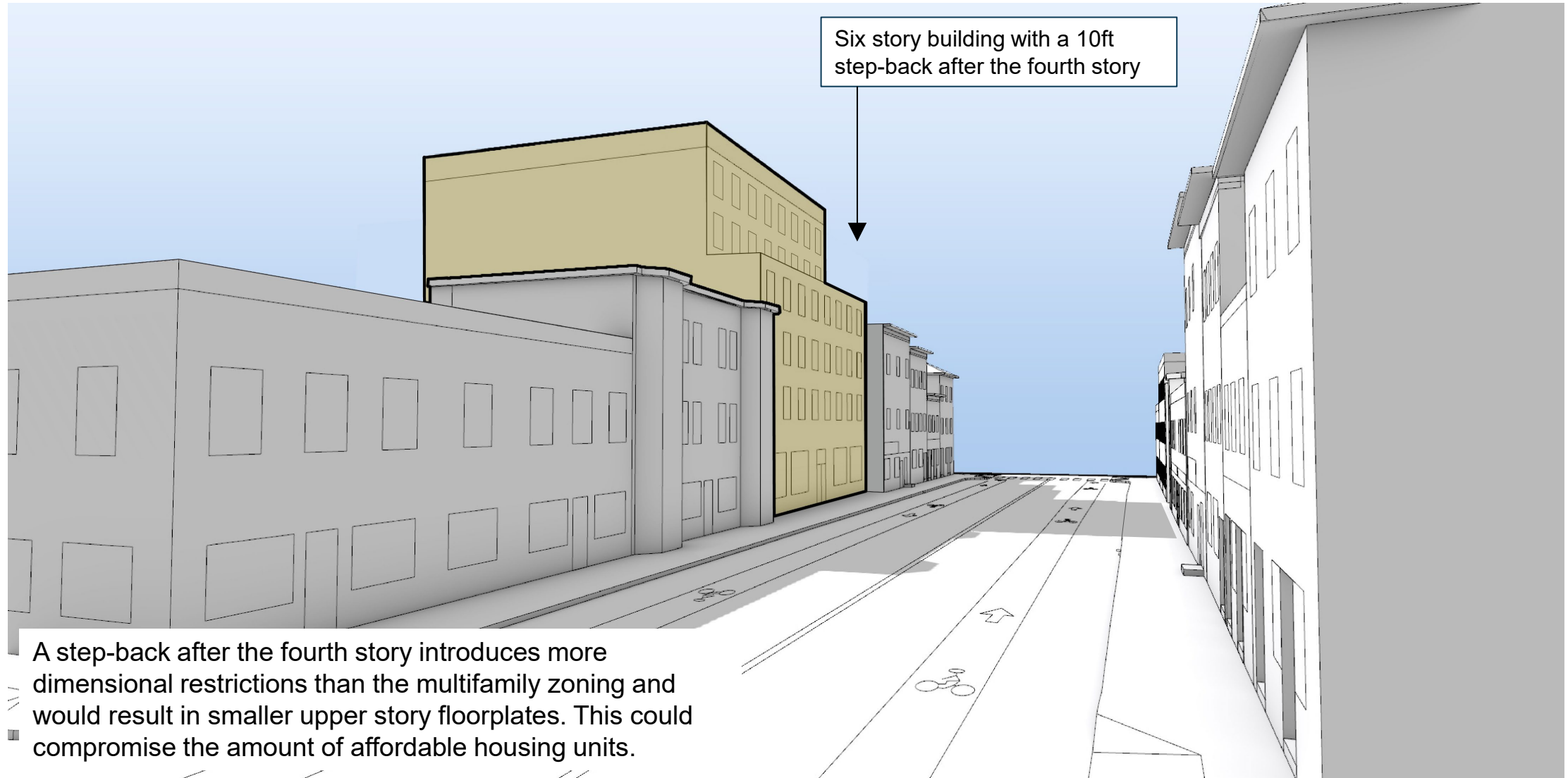


Existing narrow sidewalks on Cambridge Street.

URBAN FORM – Current zoning allows six stories on most of Cambridge St



URBAN FORM – Setbacks were discussed and included for buildings over six stories.



URBAN FORM – There are current zoning standards for Upper Story Setbacks, aka “step-backs”

Minimum Upper Story Setbacks in feet for Cambridge St Districts			
	CAM-6	CAM-10	CAM-12
Setback from Primary Street – Cambridge St, Hampshire St or Prospect St	None	14' above 75' 44' above 100'	14' above 75' 44' above 100'
Setback from Primary Street – Monsignor O'Brien Highway or North First St	None	14' above 100'	14' above 100'
Setback from Secondary Street	None	10' above 100'	12' above 75' 32' above 100'
Setback from Residence District Boundary	None	None	15' above 75'

- Site plan standards table identifies where step-back (also called “Upper Story Setbacks”) are required by district.
- Currently, step-backs only exist in CAM-10 and CAM-12 districts.

URBAN FORM – Shadow studies from Our Cambridge Street plan

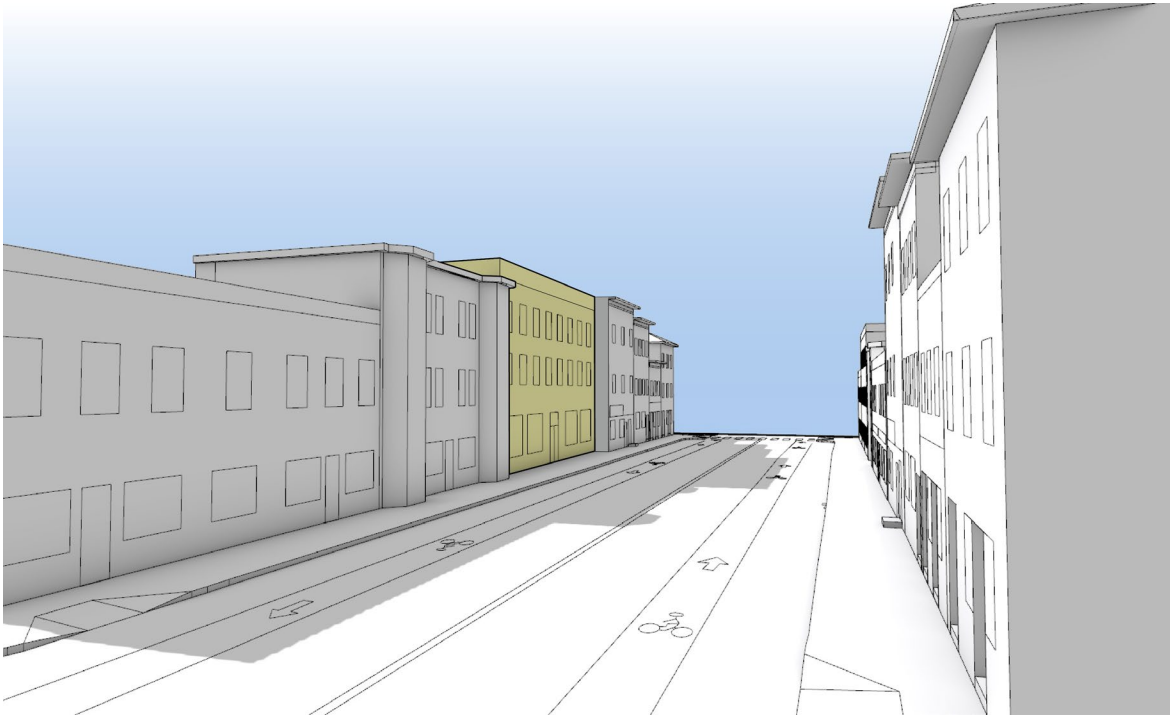


4 STORIES

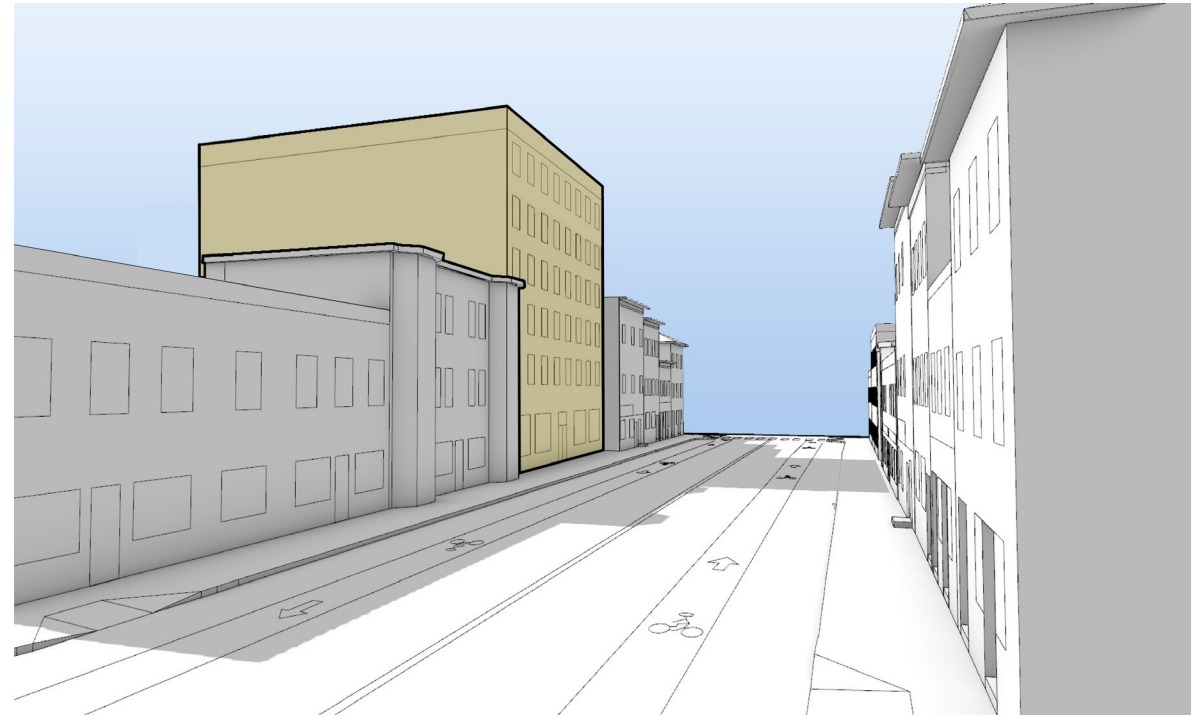
6 STORIES

Existing single-story buildings were modeled at 4 and 6 stories to show additional maximum shadows (winter solstice) illustrated in pink.

URBAN FORM: Massing and shadow comparison – 3 vs 6 story buildings



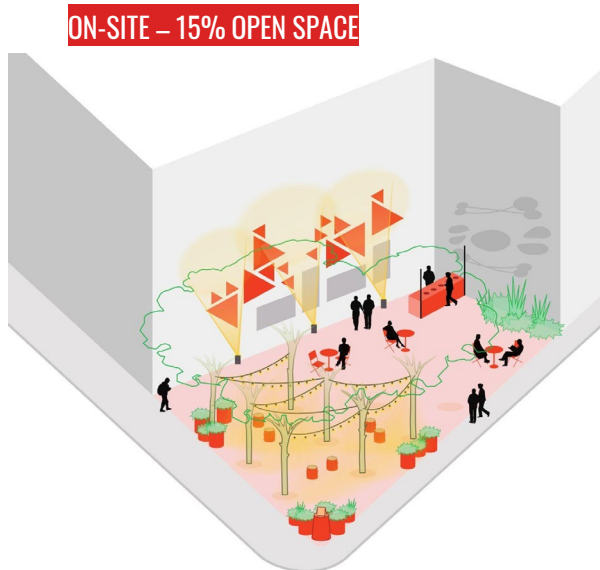
3-STORIES – Existing context



6-STORIES – Allowable height

CREATING POCKET PARKS

- Height is used to incentivize pocket parks in the zoning. Any development above 6 stories is required to provide 15% publicly accessible open space.
- Since the height is limited to 6 stories for most of the corridor, that largely applies to the Lechmere (CAM-10) and Webster/Windsor (CAM-12) sub-districts.
- There are different ways property owners can contribute towards providing a meaningful public realm – both permanent and flexible temporary spaces.



Cambridge Street Court/Yard - A temporary pocket park on City-owned land



Before – An vacant gravel lot owned by the City that was inactive space.



After – A City-owned pocket park with planting, shade, flexible seating and tables. In the future it will transform into a permanent park

DESIGN REVIEW FOR NEW DEVELOPMENT OVER 4 STORIES

- Cambridge Street Districts are considered “Areas of Special Planning Concern”. Most development must go through some kind of advisory review:
 - Staff Advisory Consultation: 0-2,000 sf (non-residential only)
 - Public Advisory Consultation: 2,000-50,000 sf
 - Planning Board Advisory Consultation: 50,000-75,000 sf
- Buildings over 4 stories would require, at least, a Public Advisory Consultation. This is a public meeting with public comment and staff comment.
- Residential uses greater than 75,000 sf need a project review special permit.

LAB USES ON CAMBRIDGE STREET

Building Use

- This is an allowed use in most districts except residential districts.
- There are other building/fire code regulations that would apply differently depending on size of building and type of use.

Building Size

- New lab buildings require building footprints that are too large for the vast majority parcels on Cambridge St.
- Most parcels on Cambridge St are only 100 feet deep.
- Lab uses are limited to a height of 3 stories or 35 feet.
- Non-residential uses are limited to an FAR of 1.0



Existing 3-story lab building on Cambridge Street. It was formerly an office building.

ENCOURAGING LOCAL RETAIL

While zoning cannot regulate businesses by ownership, e.g. chains vs. local, the city does provide a variety of programs that are aimed at local businesses including financial and educational/technical support.

Financial:

- **Storefront Improvement Program**
Reimburses funding for exterior façade renovations and ADA accessibility upgrades.
- **Small Business Enhancement Program**
Offers reimbursement grants to retail, restaurant, home-based, and creative businesses for equipment, marketing materials, or interior improvements.
- **Retail Interior Accessibility Program**
Supports interior renovations making businesses more sensory and physically accessible
- **Small Business E-Commerce Program**
Supports online and digital marketing improvements.

ENCOURAGING LOCAL RETAIL

Educational/Technical Support:

- **Small Business Coaching Program**

Provides eligible small businesses with up to 4 hours of free, one-on-one sessions with industry experts in financial planning, restaurant operations, marketing, legal setups, succession planning, and more .

- **Business Development Workshops**

Free, city-organized workshops cover topics such as marketing, social media, supplier diversity, e-commerce, accounting, and starting a business. These are open to all Cambridge small businesses.

- **Small Business Succession Planning Program**

Offers resources and events to help business owners transition ownership—via selling, employee buyouts, or succession strategies.

- **Site Search and Vacant Storefront Program**

Track ground floor vacant storefront data, provide site location services to businesses interested in locating or expanding in Cambridge, and connect eligible businesses to the Vacant Storefront Tax Program (state program).

THANKS!

